truck—he had few material possessions, had walked 13,000 kilometres in Congress yatras since 1991 and wanted only a certificate to prove he'd walked this one too. They need to be remembered, because they are the essence of the Bharat Jodo Yatra.

Ultimately this was a personal journey for all of us. We got up every day at 4 a.m. despite the body crying for more sleep, made a run to be the first to use the toilets, got dressed and wolfed down a quick breakfast before lining up for the national flag-hoisting ceremony. And then, in sunshine or darkness, rain or freezing cold, we hit the open road. We'd think to ourselves that maybe centuries ago Shankaracharya came this way, or maybe some of the Bhakti saints walked these paths too. Some of us walked in groups to the beat of music, dance and cheering crowds; others walked alone, lost in their own thoughts. But all of us walked across India in the journey of a lifetime. And it is with a sense of wonder that we recall the Yatra, as if it were a dream.

Yes, we were there. We walked across India in the pursuit of an ideal.

Not many can say that.